

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

The Seats Already Built: Staffing, Not Construction, Is Child Care's Hidden Capacity

What the child-care ecosystem means for pre-K expansion planning, 2024–2025

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

First Class Pre-K does not expand into empty space, because every new classroom opens inside Alabama's broader child-care ecosystem—2,164 licensed facilities holding 117,062 licensed slots for some 294,000 children under five. That ecosystem has a capacity problem of its own, and it is not one that new buildings would resolve. Provider surveys summarized in this project's November 2025 staffing fact sheet put licensed centers' staffed capacity at about 74 percent of what their licenses allow, with more than 20,000 unfilled positions statewide, and staffing those existing rooms would open space for roughly 14,000 additional children. For comparison, clearing First Class Pre-K's entire waitlist would seat 5,243, so in this brief we assemble the published aggregates that describe the setting in which pre-K expansion decisions are actually made.

Three findings frame the ecosystem context, and we take them up in turn below:

- **Unused licensed capacity.** A shortage of staff leaves a large block of idle licensed space, because centers operate at about 74 percent of licensed capacity and the recoverable space, roughly 14,000 children and mostly under four, exceeds the entire pre-K waitlist (figure 2).
- **Licensed versus staffed measures.** Shortage maps drawn from licenses may understate the problem, since measuring access with *staffed* rather than licensed capacity raises the estimated

infant-toddler shortage, by about 5 percentage points of tracts in a forthcoming companion analysis.

- **Pre-K growth and child-care supply.** Tracts where First Class classrooms opened in 2021–25 show about 19 percent *higher* infant-toddler capacity, which we report as an association rather than a causal estimate, and a companion analysis of national data finds no evidence that state pre-K expansion crowds out Head Start.

This is a context brief: we report published aggregates and flag forthcoming companion analyses, and we conduct no new analysis of restricted child-care data.

Pre-K Expansion and the Child-Care Market

In earlier briefs we counted pre-K’s own seats, teachers, and waitlists. Yet the families deciding whether to enroll a four-year-old are the same families arranging infant care, after-school hours, and care for siblings, and the providers hosting many First Class classrooms are child-care centers first. Expansion decisions made as though pre-K were a freestanding system therefore risk two mistakes: building where staffed capacity already sits idle, and treating the child-care workforce as separate from the pre-K workforce when the two draw from the same labor pool at similar wages (brief 8).

This brief is the twelfth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, and in it we connect the series to the child-care side of the ledger.

BOX 1

Data and Sources

Licensed supply. Published statewide aggregates from The University of Alabama’s child-care access research: 2,164 licensed facilities, 117,062 licensed day slots, 294,417 children under five (about 0.40 slots per child).

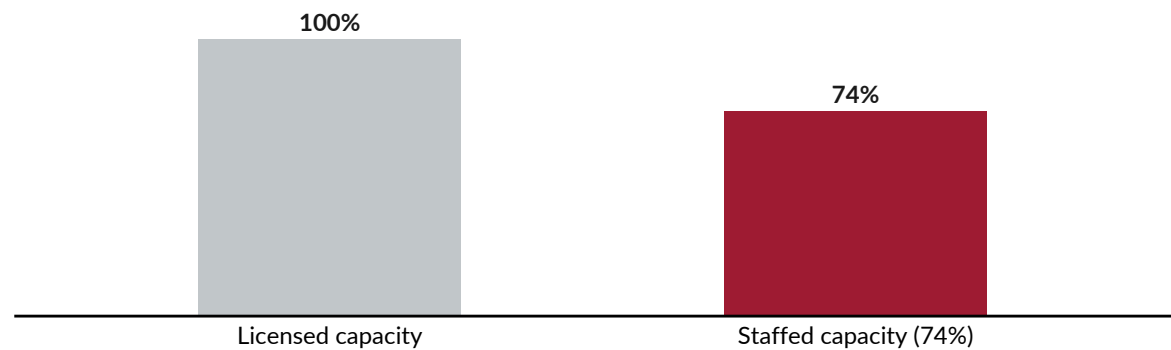
Staffing. Aggregates from the project’s November 2025 staffing fact sheet, which summarizes Alabama DHR’s quarterly provider surveys: center utilization near 74 percent of licensed capacity, 20,000-plus unfilled positions, roughly 14,000 additional children servable if existing rooms were fully staffed. DHR = Alabama Department of Human Resources, the state’s child-care licensing agency.

Forthcoming companions. The effective-capacity re-measurement and the pre-K/child-care association are UA analyses in preparation; they are cited here as forthcoming and their figures should be treated as provisional. No new analysis of restricted data appears in this brief, and no facility-level information is reported.

Licensed Capacity That Staffing Leaves Unused

Although Alabama’s child-care shortage is usually discussed in terms of construction, the staffing aggregates we summarize point elsewhere first. At about 74 percent staffed capacity (figure 1), the state’s licensed centers collectively hold roughly 14,000 children’s worth of space that has already been built, licensed, and inspected but that no one is staffed to open. Recovering that space is a hiring problem, and in our reading it would likely require the same recruitment and retention machinery this series has documented for pre-K teachers (briefs 6–8), directed at a child-care workforce that earns less still.

FIGURE 1
Centers Operate at About Three-Quarters of Licensed Capacity
Staffed capacity as a share of licensed capacity, Alabama licensed centers, 2025



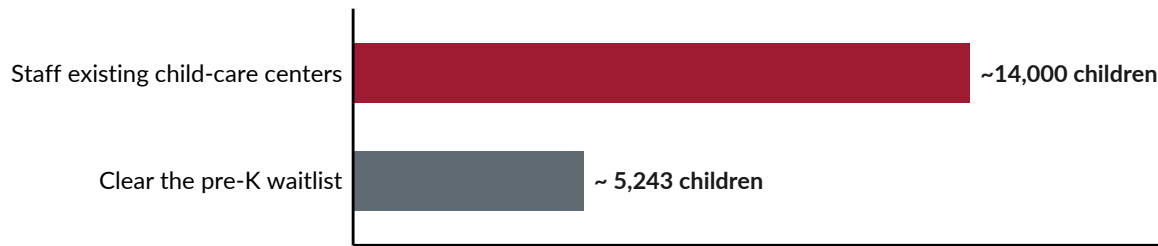
Source: Project staffing fact sheet (November 2025), summarizing Alabama DHR quarterly provider surveys.
Notes: Statewide aggregate; individual facilities vary. Licensed capacity is the regulatory maximum; staffed capacity reflects rooms actually operable with current staff.

The comparison with pre-K’s own expansion arithmetic is instructive (figure 2). Brief 9 sized the pre-K waitlist at 5,243 children, a figure that about 291 new classrooms would clear. Staffing existing child-care rooms would reach more than two and a half times as many children, most of them younger than four and therefore in the age band where Alabama’s access shortage may be deepest.

FIGURE 2

Staffing Existing Rooms Would Reach More Children than Clearing the Pre-K Waitlist

Approximate children served by each lever, statewide, 2024–2025



Source: Project staffing fact sheet (November 2025); Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama Brief 9.

Notes: The two levers serve different age groups and funding systems and are complements, not substitutes; counts are approximate planning figures.

We do not read these levers as alternatives, since they serve different children through different funding streams. What the comparison bears on is sequencing and framing, because an expansion agenda that pairs new pre-K classrooms with a child-care staffing push would address the whole age range and would avoid opening new rooms next door to licensed ones standing empty for lack of a teacher.

Does Pre-K Growth Come at Child Care's Expense?

The recurring concern about pre-K expansion is displacement, the possibility that new First Class classrooms hire away child-care staff and enroll away the four-year-olds whose fees cross-subsidize infant rooms. The evidence available to us so far does not support that concern: in a forthcoming companion analysis, the opening of First Class classrooms between 2021 and 2025 is associated with about 19 percent *higher* infant-toddler capacity in the census tracts concerned than in comparable tracts, which is the opposite sign from displacement. That difference is suggestive, yet it remains an association, and we cannot rule out the possibility that pre-K simply opened where child care was already growing. A second companion analysis, using two decades of national data, finds no evidence that state pre-K expansion reduces Head Start enrollment.

Neither result is causal proof of harmlessness, and both remain provisional until the companion analyses are complete. Yet the balance of available evidence currently runs against the displacement account, and Alabama's mixed-delivery design—which places First Class classrooms *inside* child-care centers, with the grant revenue that follows—may be part of the reason.

Discussion

The aggregates we assemble here suggest that Alabama is less short of licensed space for young children than of the people to open it, and read that way a staffing lever belongs beside the construction lever in expansion planning. A next expansion package could pair classroom grants with recruitment and retention support for the child-care workforce, including compensation supplements and the credential pathways that brief 7's waiver findings describe, and in doing so would likely reach roughly 14,000 children through rooms that already exist.

Our second implication concerns which measure of capacity planners use. Because staffed rather than licensed capacity sets the number of children a community can actually serve, siting decisions that treat licensed slots as available are likely to overbuild where rooms sit unstaffed and to underserve where licenses overstate what a community can operate. The forthcoming effective-capacity work would give planners a corrected map, although its figures should be treated as provisional until that analysis is published.

Finally, the seam between the two systems is worth measuring directly, because the pre-K and child-care workforces function as one labor market. Extending this series' roster-based turnover measurement to the child-care side, where DHR's quarterly provider surveys already collect vacancy data, would let the state observe both halves of the market it is trying to staff.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. The figures we report here are statewide aggregates, which conceal wide local variation, and no facility-level data appear anywhere in the brief. Two of the results are forthcoming and therefore provisional, since the effective-capacity and association results are cited from analyses in preparation and may be refined before publication. The estimate of roughly 14,000 children is a planning approximation, because it assumes that vacancies convert to staffed rooms at current ratios, and real hiring never converts perfectly. Finally, nothing reported here is causal, since we estimate no effect of pre-K expansion on child care or of child care on pre-K expansion.

References

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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